

HOW JAZZ IMPROVISATION

WORKS ON A

II—V—I



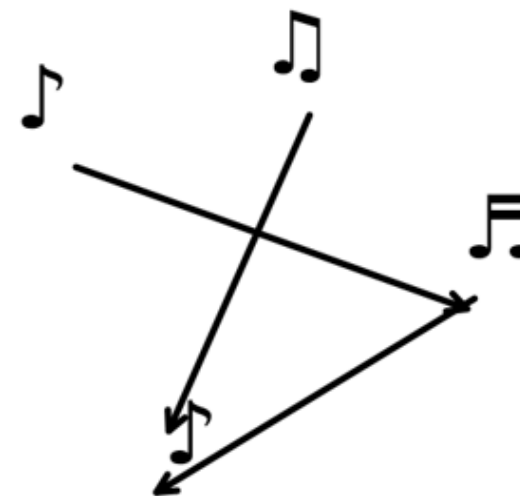
JAZZ IMPROVISATION IS NOT RANDOM

HOW MUSICIANS NAVIGATE A II—V—I USING GUIDE TONES AND VOICE LEADING

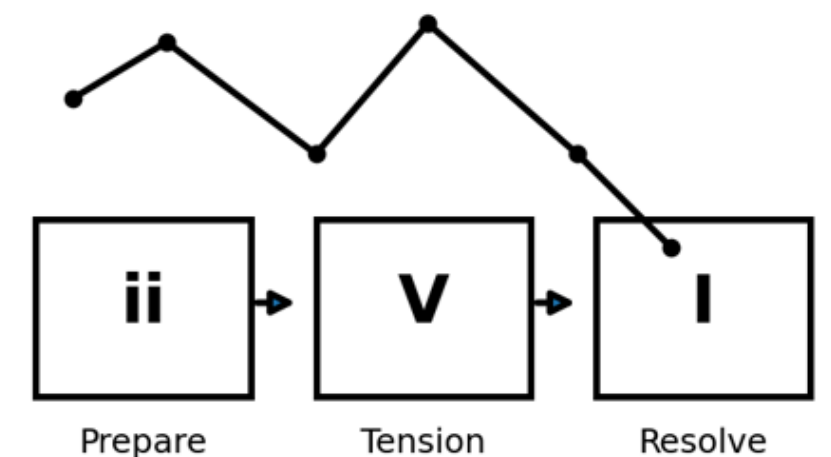
- Jazz improvisation follows the harmony (not random notes)
- A common roadmap is the ii-V-I progression
- A simple method to sound coherent over changing chords



Random?



Harmonic navigation



THE HARMONIC ROADMAP

II-V-I IN C MAJOR

- ii (Dm7): preparation
- V (G7): tension / dominant pull
- I (Cmaj7): resolution (“home”)



GUIDE TONES

3RDS AND 7THS, THE NOTES THAT DEFINE THE CHORD QUALITY



01

Landing on the 3rd or 7th makes the line sound “inside”

02

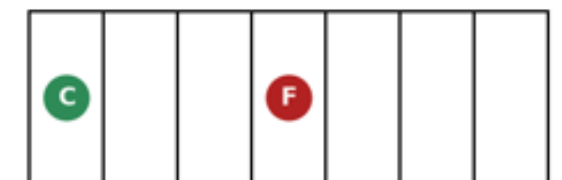
These notes carry the chord identity (minor, dominant, major)

03

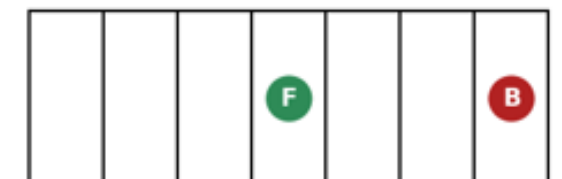
They act like a harmonic GPS

Chord	3rd	7th
Dm7	F	C
G7	B	F
Cmaj7	E	B

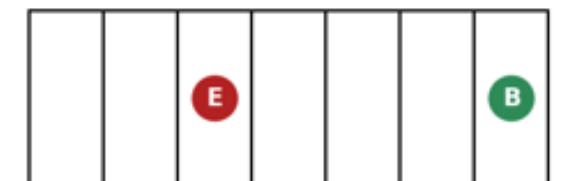
Dm7 (F,C)



G7 (B,F)



Cmaj7 (E,B)



VOICE LEADING

CONNECT CHORDS WITH SMALL MOVES

- Connect guide tones instead of restarting on every chord
- Minimal movement sounds natural and intentional



BUILDING A REAL JAZZ LINE

TARGET TONE → APPROACH NOTE → RESOLUTION

- Pick a target (3rd or 7th) for each chord
- Approach it (diatonic or chromatic)
- Resolve clearly on the I chord



PROS N CONS

PROS

- Makes improvisation more logical
- Helps beginners hear harmony
- Creates stronger melodic direction



CONS

- Can sound mechanical if overused
- Requires ear training and timing
- Theory without phrasing can sound stiff

THANKS

